

THE COMPLETE BASEBALL ANALYTICS GLOSSARY

From OPS to WAR to Bases Gained, every stat you need to understand the game.

11 ARTICLES · 4 SKILL TIERS · FREE FOR SUBSCRIBERS

How to use this guide: Read straight through for a complete analytics education, or jump to the tier that matches where you are. Every entry links to the full article on The Baseball Nerd or on Substack.

TIER 1 OF 4

THE COUNTING STATS

These are the numbers on every scoreboard. Before you can understand why the advanced metrics exist, you need to know exactly what the traditional ones count, and where they stop.

01 What is OPS in Baseball? The Complete Explanation

ON TBN

OPS stands for On-base Plus Slugging. The most widely used advanced hitting stat in mainstream coverage, and it has a structural flaw that matters more the closer you look. Covers the formula, the benchmarks, and exactly where OPS stops telling the truth.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/what-is-ops-in-baseball.html

02 What Are Total Bases in Baseball? The Complete Explanation

ON SUBSTACK

One of the oldest power metrics in baseball. Total Bases counts what happened at the plate. It does not count what happened after. A double that scores two runs and a double that strands a runner are worth exactly the same thing here.

thebaseballnerd.substack.com/p/what-are-total-bases-in-baseball

THE CONTEXT STATS

OPS tells you what happened. These stats tell you what it meant, adjusted for ballpark, league era, and run environment. wOBA and wRC+ see through conditions that fool the traditional numbers.

03

What is wOBA in Baseball?

ON TBN

Weighted On-Base Average assigns empirically derived run values to every way of reaching base. wOBA is the foundation under wRC+. Understanding it first makes everything else in Tier 2 click faster.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/what-is-woba-in-baseball.html

04

What is wRC+ in Baseball? The Stat That Actually Tells You Who Can Hit

ON TBN

wRC+ normalizes to 100. Every point above or below is a percentage point better or worse than league average. Park-adjusted, era-adjusted, context-adjusted. This is the piece that makes everything else make sense.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/what-is-wrc-plus-in-baseball.html

05

wRC+ vs OPS+: Why One Stat Actually Tells You How Good a Hitter Is

ON TBN

They look similar. They measure similar things. One of them is better. This piece does not hedge. It walks through exactly where OPS+ falls short and why wRC+ wins the argument.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/ops-plus-vs-wrc-plus.html

06

The wRC+ Quick Reference Sheet: Every Benchmark You Need

ON SUBSTACK

Understanding wRC+ conceptually and using it efficiently are two different skills. The benchmarks: what is elite, what is average, what is replacement-level, and what every tier of the scale looks like.

thebaseballnerd.substack.com/p/the-wrc-quick-reference-sheet-every

THE VALUATION STATS

How do you put one number on a player's complete value? WAR is the most cited player value metric in baseball. Bases Gained is an original stat built at The Baseball Nerd that expands the ledger further.

07

What is WAR in Baseball?

ON TBN

WAR stands for Wins Above Replacement. The premise is simple. The components are not. Covers what goes into the number, why the positional adjustment matters more than most fans realize, and how to actually use it.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/what-is-war-in-baseball.html

08

Understanding WAR: The Casual Fan's Complete Guide

ON SUBSTACK

Covers fWAR vs bWAR, why the two versions sometimes disagree, how replacement level is defined, and real-world context for what a 5-WAR season actually looks like across different positions and eras.

thebaseballnerd.substack.com/p/understanding-war-the-casual-fans

09

What a Hitter Actually Did: Introducing Bases Gained

ON TBN

Aaron Judge hit 58 home runs in 2025 with a wRC+ of 204. By every conventional measure he was the best hitter in baseball. Except Cal Raleigh did more for his team's run production that season. This is the argument Bases Gained makes.

thebaseballnerd.com/articles/bases-gained.html

10

Bases Gained: The Full Formula and 2026 Leaderboard

ON SUBSTACK

Every component of the Bases Gained formula, why each was included or excluded, what the stat cannot do, and how to read the full 2026 season leaderboard updated weekly at The Baseball Nerd.

thebaseballnerd.substack.com/p/what-a-hitter-actually-did

THE NEW RULES

The 2026 season introduced the Automated Ball-Strike system. If you have seen a hitter tap the top of his helmet and a 3D graphic flash on the scoreboard, this is what is actually happening.

11

MLB ABS Challenge Rules 2026: The Definitive Guide to the Head-Tap Replay

ON SUBSTACK

Every plate appearance in 2026 is affected by the Automated Ball-Strike challenge system. How the head-tap works, who is winning challenges, how the 3D strike zone model is defined, and what it means for how you watch every at-bat.

thebaseballnerd.substack.com/p/mlb-abs-challenge-rules-2026-the

YOU NOW HAVE THE VOCABULARY

THE BASEBALL NERD ANALYTICS SUITE

Where the vocabulary becomes a weapon. Two proprietary frameworks built and maintained at The Baseball Nerd, updated throughout the 2026 season.

SPARK SCORE

Breakout prediction for players aged 20-27. Every qualified prospect ranked by trajectory. Updated weekly.

FADE SCORE

Regression risk for players 28 and older. Who to sell before the market figures it out.